

When AI “Works,” When Does Help Begin?: Intergenerational Support Around Older Adults’ LLM Usage

HYEHYUN CHU, KAIST, Republic of Korea

YURI LEE, POSTECH, Republic of Korea

YEON SU PARK, KAIST, Republic of Korea

SAELYNE YANG, CMU, USA

JUHO KIM, KAIST, Republic of Korea and SkillBench, USA

LLMs are becoming part of everyday life, including for older adults (OAs). OAs often learn digital technologies with younger family members, who have traditionally acted as “warm experts” providing trusted and personalized operational help. LLMs expand this role: family supporters also help judge appropriate tasks, disclosure, output credibility, and when an answer is safe to act on. We report a formative qualitative study with six OAs and seven younger adults (YAs), using semi-structured interviews and scenario-based think-aloud activities. We found that OAs used GenAI to reduce repeated dependence on family while preserving family as a selectively invoked support channel. Because LLMs rarely produced visible operational breakdowns, families had limited signals for when support was needed and negotiated intervention through partial disclosure, general warnings, and action boundaries. Family support often solved an immediate problem without leaving reusable calibration knowledge. Based on these findings, we propose design implications for intergenerational LLM support (e.g., consentful help requests, learning-oriented family support that preserves OA task ownership).

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; **Empirical studies in accessibility**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: Older Adults, LLM chatbots, Intergenerational Support, Family Collaboration

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1 Introduction

Older Adults (OAs) (aged 60 or above [2, 8]) rarely encounter new technologies, such as smartphones, alone by themselves. Family members, particularly children and grandchildren, are a common source of informal support for learning smartphones, internet services, and other digital tools [6, 7]. Such supporters are often described as *warm experts*: trusted members of an OA’s close social network who offer patient, personalized help within an ongoing relationship, rather than formal and task-bounded instruction [5]. This relational support can create meaningful learning opportunities, enabling OAs to develop digital-media skills through guidance that is responsive to their everyday needs and circumstances [3].

Large language models (LLMs), such as ChatGPT, possess the possibility to reshape intergenerational support. Recent work describes younger family members moving from *warm experts* who teach operation toward *warm stewards* who also interpret risks, negotiate boundaries of use, and provide emotional reassurance [9]. Supporters may need to help OAs decide which tasks are appropriate for AI, what personal information can be shared, which outputs require verification, and when an answer is safe to act on. These are judgments that younger helpers may not have fully mastered themselves. However, this shift’s everyday interactional consequences remain underexplored.

As a first step toward systems that support this emerging stewardship, we conducted a formative study with six OAs and seven younger adults (YAs) using semi-structured interviews and scenario-based think-aloud activities. We examine this tension through three questions:

Authors’ Contact Information: Hye Hyun Chu, KAIST, Daejeon, Republic of Korea, hyenchu@kaist.ac.kr; Yuri Lee, POSTECH, Pohang, Republic of Korea; Yeon Su Park, KAIST, Daejeon, Republic of Korea; Saelyne Yang, CMU, Pittsburgh, USA; Juho Kim, KAIST, Daejeon, Republic of Korea and SkillBench, Santa Barbara, CA, USA.

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- (1) **RQ1:** How do older adults incorporate LLM into day to day life?
- (2) **RQ2:** How does intergenerational support around older adults' LLM use happen?
- (3) **RQ3:** What challenges exist during intergenerational support around older adults' LLM use?

Our findings both extend the warm-steward account and expose a feedback problem. For OAs, risk-related warnings arrived without a stated reason, so OAs often read them as criticism rather than actionable guidance. While YAs, lacking visibility into OAs' subsequent sessions, had no way to confirm whether their interventions had actually changed OAs' practices. We contribute an account of intergenerational LLM chatbot support as relational boundary work, and identify design opportunities for protective collaboration that closes this feedback gap while preserving OA control and autonomy [4].

2 Methodology

We recruited six OAs, consisting of two males and four females, with ages ranging from 60 to 70 years ($M = 64.5$, $SD = 3.83$). We also recruited seven YAs, consisting of five males and two females, with ages ranging from 24 to 34 years ($M = 27.4$, $SD = 3.26$). All OAs reported currently using at least one LLM service. Each YA discussed a parent or grandparent who used LLM and with whom they had exchanged, or could exchange, support around its use. Participant demographics are summarized in Appendix A.

We recruited the OAs through online community forums in South Korea centered around keywords such as *senior* and *retiree*, where OAs actively participate, promotional posters placed at welfare centers, and snowballing through YA participants. The inclusion criteria required participants to (1) be at least 60 years old, following the definition of OAs in the existing literature [2, 8], (2) report using LLM chatbots (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini), and (3) have experience giving or receiving family-based support related to LLM chatbot use. Each OA received KRW 50,000 ($\approx$ USD 38), and each YA received KRW 20,000 ($\approx$ USD 14) for participation. The higher OA compensation reflected the greater difficulty of recruiting eligible OA participants.

Two OA–YA pairs participated as matched dyads. We assigned each pair a shared numeric suffix (OA1–YA1 and OA2–YA2). We assigned the remaining participants independent identifiers (OA3–OA6 and YA3–YA7).

2.1 Procedure and Analysis

2.1.1 Study Procedure. Each session lasted approximately 60 minutes and consisted of three parts: (1) an opening interview, (2) a live scenario-based task, and (3) a family-help recall interview.

Part 1: Opening Interview. The session began with questions about participants' AI practices, confidence in using LLMs, privacy-related choices, and strategies for verifying AI-generated information.

Part 2: Live Scenario-Based Task. Participants then selected a recent or realistic health- or legal/regulatory-related concern and used an LLM chatbot on their own phone or computer while thinking aloud and sharing their screen with the interviewer. The interviewer let ordinary pauses unfold and intervened only after around 30 seconds of silence, when needed. During this task, we observed participants' prompt construction and refinement, verification behaviors, use of prior knowledge, and help-seeking behaviors.

Part 3: Family-Help Recall Interview. The session concluded with a reconstruction of a recent family-help episode. OA participants were asked about requesting, accepting, or resisting help from family members, while YA participants were asked about helping, gatekeeping, and their sense of responsibility toward older relatives. Both groups reflected on their preferences regarding timing, context sharing, and desired support.

2.1.2 Data Analysis. All interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed. We conducted thematic analysis on the transcripts following Braun and Clarke [1] to identify recurring patterns across participants' accounts. Two authors carried out an iterative coding process: they first independently coded transcripts from three participants in each group (OA and YA) to develop preliminary codes and an initial codebook, then reconciled discrepancies and refined code definitions through discussion. The resulting codebook was then applied independently by the two authors to the remaining transcripts. Newly emerging codes and interpretive disagreements were resolved through team meetings.

3 Results

This section presents five findings organized around our three research questions, covering how OAs incorporate LLM chatbots into later life, how intergenerational support around this use unfolds, and what challenges arise within that support.

3.0.1 RQ1: How Older Adults Incorporate LLM into Day to Day Life.

F1: LLM use as a way to stay independent within family relationships. OAs used LLMs not just to acquire a new skill, but to strengthen their autonomy within family relationships. Many turned to LLMs instead of asking their children for help with IT or everyday questions, wanting to be independent and to spare their children’s time and attention. This was less a rejection of family help than a form of relational autonomy, letting OAs control which questions they brought to family in the first place. For instance, OA6 mentioned, “My son is really busy, so if I can search and learn it myself, there’s no need to keep asking him. I just try it on my own, and only ask when I really can’t figure it out.” LLMs also let some OAs selectively showcase new competence to family rather than only receiving help, while family remained a channel where they felt safe honestly admitting what they didn’t know. OAs further framed their own use as modest, everyday, and low-stakes by contrast with how they imagined YAs’ more consequential use, even when the domains involved (health, housing, finance, tax) were objectively high-stakes. Verification effort tracked perceived stakes rather than following a fixed rule. Rather than age itself, OAs experienced a shortage of opportunities and contexts to learn as the real constraint on expanding their use. Although they wished to broaden how they used technology, circumstances such as retirement made this expansion feel difficult to pursue.

F2: LLMs’ fluency reshaped OAs’ sense of using AI well. Because LLMs generate a fluent, on-topic answer to almost any input, OAs treated receiving an answer as itself the sign of successful use. They incorporated chatbots as an always-available, low-friction resource for nearly anything, and voice use increased with age (OA5, OA6). On free-tier models, this resource was experienced simply as “the AI.” Operational steps (install, login, voice input) were familiar from prior technologies, and this was the point where OAs most readily asked family for help. Judging what to ask and how much to trust an answer, by contrast, were newer skills OAs were still building on their own, without a fixed rule for when to double-check. YA2 stated, “They (my parents) don’t seem able to tell whether information is trustworthy or just sounds plausible.” Since asking a question and getting an answer had little friction once set up, sustained use required relatively little further operational support compared to prior smartphone use, and declining vision and typing difficulty pushed voice input further, which meant OAs less often encountered the visual source links and warnings that chat interfaces display. In addition, during the Live Scenario-Based Task, OAs tended to start prompting with broad, general questions and converge through repeated back-and-forth, in contrast to YAs’ upfront, condition-specific prompts. This could have meant OAs needed to work harder to evaluate what came back, with errors sometimes surfacing only several turns after building on a flawed premise.

3.0.2 RQ2: How Intergenerational Support around OAs’ LLM Use Happens.

F3: Families chose help that was easy to give, not easy to reuse. Beyond light, recurring operational help, family support took four distinct forms: *prompt completion*, writing or solving the task directly and handing over only the result; *brief verbal rules*, short warnings like “don’t trust it too much” offered when no clear friction seemed to warrant more; *demonstration*, walking OA through steps or sources in person; and *use case observation*, where OA discovered new capabilities simply by seeing what a family member had made. YAs chose among them by perceived efficiency and friction in the moment rather than by what the parent could reuse afterward. These forms tended to emerge from incidental contact rather than planned teaching, and the absence of operational friction was read by YAs as a sign that no intervention was needed. YA3 mentioned, “I think I mostly picked this up through conversation, since I’m not with my parents all the time.”

3.0.3 RQ3: Challenges in Intergenerational Support around OAs’ LLM Use.

F4: Support rarely accumulated into reusable applicable knowledge. Family support solved immediate problems but unevenly translated into the independence OAs said they wanted next, since success meant not just one good output but whether OA could later perform a similar task alone. Prompt completion left a result but not a method, and brief warnings were low-burden but, without accompanying reasons, tended to close off the conversation; task-specific method advice, by contrast, carried into future behavior. OA2 described, “He (their son) just solves it and gives it to me. He doesn’t teach me the method, so next time I still can’t do it

and have to ask him again, if he taught me the method, I could do it myself after that.” Of the four forms, only demonstration and method-oriented advice reliably built this kind of reusable knowledge, yet neither was a priority under YAs’ selection criteria of immediate results and low friction. Both OA and YA wanted OA’s use to expand, but no sustained family structure existed to support that growth.

F5: Partial visibility turned support into unspoken boundary work. OA and YA each inferred the other’s ability and risk from partial, fragmentary observations rather than a full view of each other’s LLM use, which cut asymmetrically. YAs felt responsible for judging and protecting their parents’ use without being able to see all of it, while OAs inferred YA’s competence mainly from age and occupation. For instance, OA3 said, “I really have no idea... I don’t know at all how my child uses it. I think they probably use it in their own way (...) but I think they’re able to use it appropriately for their age.” Standards for “using AI well” also diverged within dyads. OAs judged themselves by prompting skill, while YAs judged parents by their ability to distinguish trustworthy answers from plausible-sounding ones, showing that AI competence spans distinct dimensions (operation, utilization, calibration) that the two generations weighed differently. Task boundaries were drawn differently too. Given the same open-ended scenario, YAs framed questions at a practical management level while OAs raised higher-stakes matters simply because these were the real problems in their current lives, and YAs treated the meaningful boundary as the point where an unverified answer turned into action rather than whether a high-stakes question was asked at all. This boundary was never made a topic of explicit family conversation: OA chose what to show, YA filled gaps with assumptions, and intervention arrived only as brief, after-the-fact warnings, with no one’s authority to set the boundary ever made explicit.

4 Design Implications

Building on these findings, we propose design implications for systems that support families in providing LLM support.

Turn struggles that never fail into recognizable signals. Because an LLM produces a fluent answer to almost any input, difficulties with utilization and calibration rarely surface the way an operational failure would; OAs can be struggling with a task while nothing on screen looks broken. Systems should not let “an answer was returned” stand in for “this was used well.” Instead, in-the-moment uncertainty, such as an unusually broad or repeated question, a claim that runs against what the OA already knows, or a jump straight from answer to action, should be surfaced as a signal the OA can recognize and act on, whether for their own reflection or to share with family.

Turn family support into actionable, reusable guidance. Brief warnings (“don’t trust it too much”) and prompt completion each break down along a different axis: the former lacks the specificity to be acted on, the latter lacks the durability to be reused. Systems should help family support persist as concrete steps, attached to a reason, in a form the OA can call on again later, rather than dissolving into a one-off fix or a vague rule.

Furthermore, supporting OA’s question structuring, and widen the OA’s everyday repertoire will be helpful. Structuring a question is itself a way of pre-setting evaluation criteria, so support given upfront also lowers the verification burden downstream. Absent a learning channel after retirement and a context for repeated practice, this front-loaded support matters more than age itself. Use-case observation, where an OA tries something new simply after seeing what a family member made, without any explanation, was in practice the pathway that most reliably expanded an OA’s repertoire, suggesting that systems should support this kind of ambient exposure rather than relying only on explicit instruction.

Let the OA control the scope, timing, and audience of support. OAs were not motivated by eliminating dependence on family, but by regulating what they handled alone and what they brought to family on their own terms. Systems should let the OA decide which conversations to share, whether to request an answer or just a verification method, and when to open the door to intervention. This sharing should work as more than a channel for requesting help: it should also let the OA show competence to family, the pride and common ground that some OAs described finding in AI use.

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A Appendix

Table 1. Demographic characteristics and self-reported LLM usage patterns of the six older-adult (OA) participants, including the specific LLM services used, length of usage experience, and typical use frequency.

ID	Age	Gender	LLM services	Experience	Use frequency
OA1	60	F	Perplexity, Gemini	3–6 months	3–4 days/week
OA2	61	M	ChatGPT, Gemini	6–12 months	1–2 days/week
OA3	63	F	ChatGPT, Gemini	Over 1 year	Almost daily
OA4	66	M	ChatGPT, Gemini	3–6 months	1–2 days/week
OA5	67	F	Gemini	3–6 months	Almost daily
OA6	70	F	Gemini	Over 1 year	1–2 days/week

Table 2. Demographic characteristics and family context of the seven younger-adult (YA) participants, showing each participant’s relationship to their older relative, whether that relative was also an OA participant in this study (indicated in the “Matched OA” column; “—” denotes older relatives who did not themselves participate), the older relative’s age, and the pair’s living arrangement and contact frequency.

ID	Age	Gender	Relation	Matched OA	Relative age	Co-residence & contact
YA1	28	M	Child	OA1	60	Co-resident
YA2	27	M	Child	OA2	61	Co-resident
YA3	26	M	Grandchild	—	79	Separate; contact 1–3 times/month
YA4	24	M	Grandchild	—	75	Separate; contact at least weekly
YA5	25	F	Child	—	64	Co-resident
YA6	34	M	Child	—	62	Separate; contact at least weekly
YA7	28	F	Child	—	61	Co-resident